

IR II: Liberalism (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: PG = Goldstein & Pevehouse, *International Relations* — ch. 3, §3.1 (*The Waning of War*) & §3.2 (*Liberal Theories*) + ch. 7 (*International Organizations, Law, and Human Rights*). ·

Lecturer: Ayça Uygur Wessel.

Theme of the lecture (AUW — deck). Liberalism as the **theoretical response to realism**. Realism explains rivalry, competition, security dilemmas and arms races — *but what about* European integration, IOs, international trade, arms-control agreements, and the democratic peace? **Liberalism's puzzle:** *if the international system is anarchic, why do states cooperate at all — and under what conditions is cooperation more or less likely?*

★ **The heart of the lecture:** liberalism keeps realism's starting point — **states are rational, self-interested actors under anarchy** — but reaches the opposite conclusion: **self-interest does not necessarily produce conflict**. Because some interests **overlap**, cooperation is often the rational choice: **self-interest → mutual benefits → reasoned cooperation → stable cooperation**. Two branches say how: **liberal institutionalism** — *institutions* make cooperation easier (information, reciprocity, monitoring, enforcement, the shadow of the future); and **liberal internationalism** — *domestic politics* shape what states want (the Kantian triangle: democracy + interdependence + IOs). *Liberalism ≠ being nice or naïve — it's "under what conditions is cooperation in states' own interest?"*

The red thread. For any case ask: *cooperation looks impossible under anarchy — so what makes it happen here?* Either the answer is **institutional** (rules/monitoring/reciprocity change the incentives) or it is **domestic** (regime type, interests, public opinion shape state preferences). Both keep the realist assumption of self-interested rational states.

Three things liberalism is NOT (deck). Liberalism in IR ≠ **economic liberalism** (free markets) ≠ **liberalism in domestic politics** (a left-right ideology). In IR it is a **theory of cooperation under anarchy**.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **The cooperation puzzle** — why cooperate under anarchy? (the question realism can't answer well).
- **Two branches: liberal institutionalism** (Keohane, Nye — international level) vs **liberal internationalism** (Kant — domestic/unit level).
- **Neoliberal institutionalism** — concedes realism's assumptions (unitary, rational, anarchy) but shows cooperation still pays.
- **Reciprocity & the shadow of the future · information/monitoring/transparency · enforcement · issue linkage.**
- **International regime** (Krasner) — "principles, norms, rules, and decision-making procedures around which actor expectations converge." (*An international institution ≠ an IO.*)
- **Complex interdependence** (Keohane & Nye) — multiple channels; disruption is costly for both sides (sensitivity vs vulnerability).

- The Kantian triangle — democracy + economic interdependence + international organizations.
- Democratic peace — democracies almost never fight *each other*.
- Collective security · IGOs/NGOs · the UN · international law · just war · human rights (ch.7).

Section-by-section main points

A. How liberalism sees the world (*deck* + §3.1–3.2 intro)

Core: liberalism is **more optimistic** than realism about peace and progress, but it is **not** starry-eyed: states are still **rational actors pursuing self-interest** — the liberal twist is that **self-interest often points to cooperation, not conflict**.

- **The chain (deck):** self-interest → mutual benefits → reasoned cooperation → stable cooperation. Cooperation is possible **without** becoming altruistic.
- **Realism vs liberalism on the "rules of IR":** realists see power politics as **timeless**; liberals see the rules as **slowly, incrementally evolving toward peace** — through the buildup of **international organizations + reciprocity** (and secondarily changing **norms/public opinion**). Liberalism draws on the **reciprocity and identity** principles, where realism draws on **dominance**.
- **§3.1 The Waning of War (the empirical backdrop):** contrary to the media impression, this is **one of the least warlike periods ever**. Battle-deaths have fallen sharply since WWII (tens of millions → millions → hundreds of thousands); the **last great-power war ended 60+ years ago**; today's conflicts (Syria, Yemen, Ukraine) are, by historical standards, **small wars**. → *This trend is what liberalism claims to explain and realism struggles to.*

B. The two branches of liberalism (*deck*)

Core: liberalism gives **two** answers to realism — one at the **international** level, one at the **domestic** level.

	Liberal Institutionalism	Liberal Internationalism
Key names	Keohane & Nye	Kant
Main question	How can states cooperate despite anarchy?	Why do states <i>want</i> different things?
Level of analysis	International (systemic)	Domestic / unit level
Core mechanisms	Information · reciprocity · monitoring · enforcement	Regime type · institutions · interests · public opinion
Simple claim	Institutions make cooperation easier	Domestic politics shape state preferences

(*Deck aside: liberal internationalism's focus on the domestic level mirrors what neoclassical realism does on the realist side — both "open up" the state rather than treating it as a black box.*)

C. ★ Liberal institutionalism — what makes cooperation possible (§3.2.2 + deck)

Core: neoliberal (institutionalist) thinking says to realists: "Even granting your assumptions — unitary, rational states under anarchy — your pessimism doesn't follow." States cooperate often because it's in their interest, and **institutions** help them do it by **changing the incentives**. The engine is **reciprocity**, which enforces rules **without a world government**.

- **International institution** ≠ **IO** (Krasner 1983). An international regime/institution = "principles, norms, rules, and decision-making procedures around which actor expectations converge" — not just the UN or EU, but **monitoring arrangements, agreements, and platforms**. Institutions **structure repeated interaction**.
- **The four mechanisms (the deck's core — how institutions enable cooperation):**
 1. **The shadow of the future.** In a **one-shot** game, cheating pays; in **repeated** interaction, cheating invites **future retaliation**. A **longer time horizon + more future interaction** → **higher cost of defection** → **cooperation more attractive**. (*This is the repeated Prisoner's Dilemma — see IR I — solved by tit-for-tat: cooperate first, then mirror.*)
 2. **Information changes the game.** **Reporting** (what parties say) + **monitoring** (what they actually do) → **transparency** → easier detection of violations → **less uncertainty, less fear of cheating**. (*Ex: the European Semester — the EU monitors member states' budgets to deter "excessive deficits."*)
 3. **Reciprocity & enforcement.** **Reciprocity** = **responding in kind** — meet **cooperation with cooperation** and **defection with punishment** (*positive reciprocity rewards; negative reciprocity retaliates*). It is **liberalism's answer to "who enforces the rules when there is no world government?"** — states police each other by making **defection cost you tomorrow's cooperation** (*tit-for-tat: cooperate first, then mirror*). So **cooperation** ≠ **harmony** — it needs bargaining and adjustment, and persists **only when defection has consequences**. Institutions supply the machinery: **detect** (monitoring) → **respond** (reciprocity) → **raise the cost** (enforcement) → plus **issue linkage** (cooperate across issues so a concession on one trades for another). (*Ex: rule-of-law sanctions — the EU froze Hungary's funds.*) **The double edge:** the same reciprocity can spiral into **runaway hostility** — endless mutual punishment (Israel–Palestine).
 4. **Interdependence makes conflict costly.** Complex interdependence (≠ friendship, ≠ one-way dependence): states are tied through **trade, investment, finance, supply chains, people, and communication** across *multiple channels*. Disrupting the relationship is **costly for both sides** → **stronger incentives to negotiate**. (*But interdependence is often asymmetric — the textbook's sensitivity [you can find another supplier] vs vulnerability [you can't].*)
- **The neoliberal PD argument:** each actor can gain by defecting, but both lose if both defect; in **repeated play, strict reciprocity (tit-for-tat)** brings mutual cooperation. **Danger:** reciprocity can also produce **runaway hostility** — a nasty tit-for-tat of punishments (Israel–Palestine).
- **The EU — "a liberal-institutionalism masterpiece" (deck):** European states have **shared interests and incentives to defect**; the institutional solution — **permanent forums, common rules, monitoring, courts/enforcement, issue linkage, repeated interaction** — makes cooperation **easier and more predictable**. After centuries of war, Europe now enjoys a **stable peace**. (*Yet members still "cheat" over the years — cooperation is managed, not automatic.*)

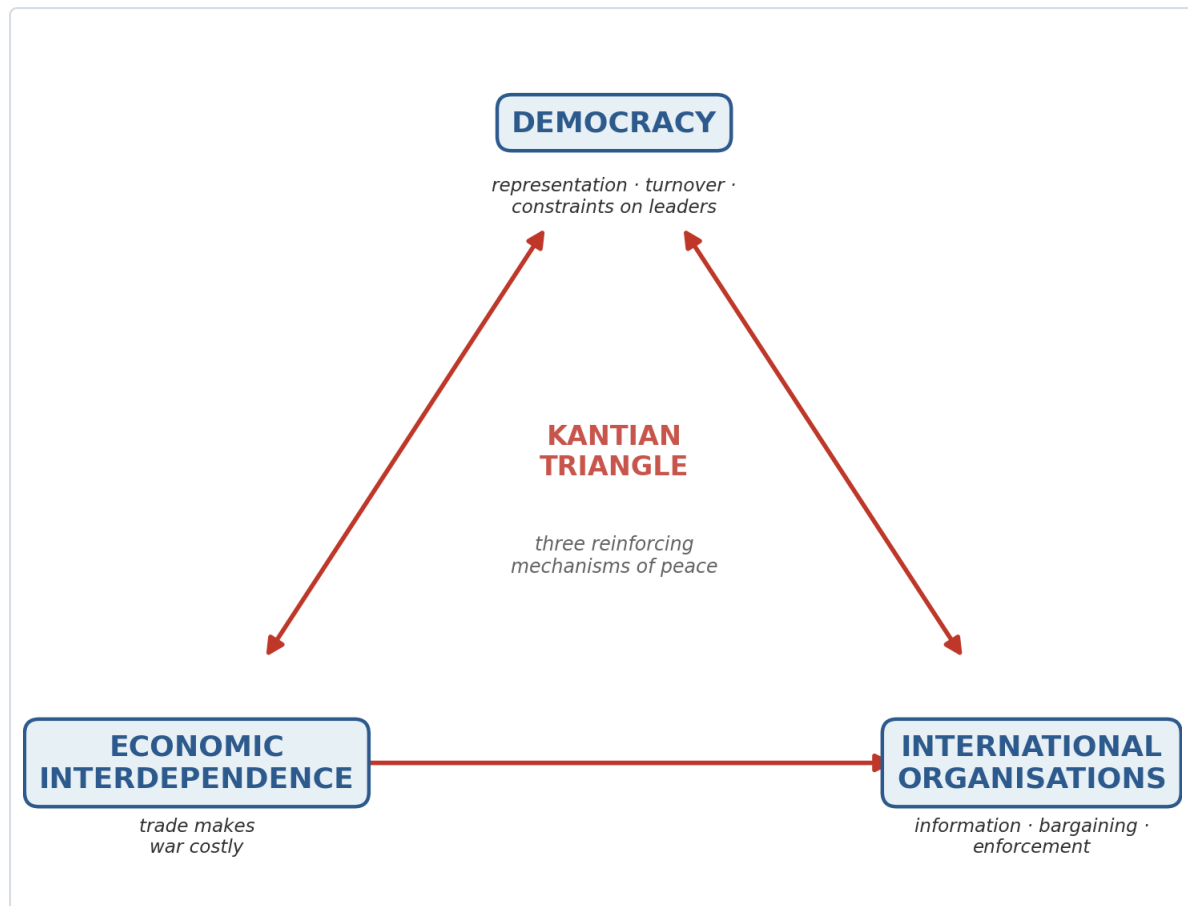
D. International regimes & collective security (§3.2.3–3.2.4)

Core: regimes are how liberalism operationalises cooperation in an issue area; collective security is the security-side application (all against any aggressor).

- International regime = rules/norms/procedures where expectations **converge** in an issue area (arms control, trade, oceans). Regimes **increase transparency** (cheating is riskier) and **facilitate/empower** states rather than constrain them — they "open up new possibilities with more favorable cost–benefit ratios."
- **Hegemonic stability (a realist–liberal blend):** regimes are often most effective when power is **concentrated** (a **hegemon** to enforce them) — but once expectations converge, regimes can **outlive the hegemon** ("take on a life of their own"; US economic regimes survived US relative decline in the 1970s). Regimes often **embed** in permanent institutions (**UN, NATO, IMF**).
- Collective security (grows out of liberal institutionalism; Kant's federation): a **broad alliance of most major actors** jointly opposing **aggression by any actor**. Success needs (1) members to **keep commitments** (no free-riding) and (2) agreement on **what counts as aggression**. It **fails against great-power aggression** (the veto).
 - **League of Nations** — failed (no US; members unwilling to bear costs → Japan, Italy in the 1930s). **UN** = its successor.
 - Gulf War 1990–91 — collective security worked (Iraq's blatant conquest of Kuwait united the great powers). Iraq 2003 — it *split* the great powers (France threatened a veto; US/UK/Australia acted anyway).

E. ★ Liberal internationalism & the Kantian triangle (§3.2.1 + deck)

Core: liberal internationalism opens the domestic "black box": what a state *wants* (its preferences) depends on **who has a say inside it**. Kant's three answers to "how is peace possible?" form the Kantian triangle.



How to read it (the Kantian triangle). Kant gave **three** routes to peace, and they **reinforce** each other:

- **Democracy** — republics with **legislatures that check the leader** are constrained from going to war lightly (representation, leadership turnover, accountability). (→ the democratic peace.)
- **Economic interdependence** — **trade increases wealth and mutual dependence**, so war becomes **costly** and less attractive. (Kant's "*trade promotes peace*"; realists are *skeptical* — interdependence was high before WWI, yet war came.)
- **International organisations** — a **federation of states** (Kant's proposal → today's **UN**) provides **information, bargaining, and enforcement**, letting states forgo short-term gains for long-term cooperation. (→ liberal institutionalism.)
- **The point:** each corner makes the others more effective; together they explain why, despite anarchy, the world has grown **more peaceful**.
- **The causal chain of liberal internationalism (deck):** **domestic institutions + interests + incentives** (who benefits? who has influence?) → **state preferences** (what does the government want?) → **foreign policy** (which international choice follows) → **international outcome** (cooperation, conflict, or variation across states).
- **Who's in the black box:** president/PM/monarch, parliament, courts, bureaucracies, business & labour, elections, interest groups, media & public opinion. → *This is why liberalism sits at the **domestic level of analysis** (contra realism's systemic focus).*

F. The democratic peace (§3.2.5 + deck)

Core: the democratic peace = the strongly-supported empirical finding that **democracies almost never fight each other** — though they fight authoritarian states as much as anyone. (Democratic peace ≠ "democracies are peaceful.")

- **Not true:** that democracies are *generally* more peaceful — they fight as many wars as autocracies (the most war-prone states of the past two centuries were **France, Russia, Britain**).
- **True:** no major historical case of two democracies going to war with each other.
- **Why (candidate mechanisms — the deck's exercise):** ① **public opinion & representation** (the public, whose support wars need, resists); ② **peaceful leadership turnover** (no need to fight to change rulers); ③ **transparency & mutual understanding** (democracies read each other's intentions); ④ **institutional constraints** (checks and balances slow the war decision). Also: democracies are usually **capitalist** with strong **trade interdependence**, and citizens **don't see other democracies as enemies**.
- **Why it matters theoretically:** the democratic peace is rooted in the **domestic** level → it **contradicts realism's** claim that the systemic level explains the most.
- **Caveats (don't oversell it):** **democratization/transition** may be *more* war-prone than stable regimes (e.g. Hamas elected 2006); and **democratic institutions can make cooperation harder** — legislatures raise **tariffs**, publics block IOs (US & the League of Nations; **Brexit**).

G. The institutions themselves — IOs, the UN, international law & human rights (ch. 7)

Core: ch. 7 is the **empirical "flesh"** on liberal institutionalism — the actual institutions through which states cooperate under anarchy. All of them are **limited by state sovereignty** (there is **no world government**), yet they **structure order** through norms, reciprocity, and legitimacy.

- **IGOs vs NGOs (§7.1):** **IGOs** = members are **states** (UN, OPEC, WTO, EU); **NGOs** = private/specialised (Amnesty, Greenpeace, Red Cross, religious bodies). The web of IOs has grown steadily → rising **interdependence**.
- **The UN (§7.2)** — "*the closest thing to a world government that has ever existed, but it is not a world government.*" It exists because **states created it to serve their needs** (membership = **indirect leverage**). Key organs:
 - **Security Council** — maintains peace; decisions **binding**; **5 permanent members (US, UK, France, Russia, China)** with the **veto** + 10 rotating members. A single permanent-member **veto** kills a resolution → **paralysis when great powers are involved** (Russia shielding Syria).
 - **Peacekeeping** ("Chapter 6½"; **blue helmets**) — serve at the **host's invitation**, neutral between combatants (Nobel Peace Prize 1988).
 - **General Assembly** — all **193 members, one vote each** — a "global town hall" (declarations are **not binding law**).
 - **Secretariat / Secretary-General** — administration + **neutral mediator** ("good offices").
 - **Specialised agencies** — WHO, ITU, ICAO; and the economic ones (**World Bank, IMF, WTO**).
- **International law (§7.3)** — derives **not** from a world legislature but from **tradition and agreement**. **Four sources:** **treaties** (most important; *pacta sunt servanda* — treaties must be kept), **custom**,

general principles, legal scholarship. Enforcement has no world police → rests on **reciprocity + collective response** (sanctions, reprisals) → therefore **depends on power** (easy to cheat on small issues / if you're strong). The **World Court (ICJ, The Hague)** hears only **state-vs-state** cases (limited jurisdiction).

- **Law & sovereignty (§7.4): diplomatic law** (immunity; sanctity of embassies — the **Iran hostage crisis 1979**) is the bedrock. **Just-war doctrine: laws of war (*jus ad bellum*)** — when war is legal (**only in response to aggression**; intent must be just) — vs **laws in war (*jus in bello*)** — how it may be fought.
- **Human rights (§7.5):** the idea of universal human rights **clashes with sovereignty (universalism vs relativism)**; China/Russia call criticism "interference in internal affairs"). Sources: **religion, natural-law philosophy (Locke, Kant, Rousseau), the 18th-c. revolutions. Civil-political ("negative") vs economic-social ("positive") rights.** The **UDHR (1948)** sets norms (not binding law). **R2P (responsibility to protect, 2005)** — states must protect civilians from genocide/crimes against humanity (invoked for **Libya 2011**; *failed* in **Syria**). **War crimes → the ICC** (from **Nuremberg's "crimes against humanity"** → Yugoslavia/Rwanda tribunals → the International Criminal Court).

Cases & examples

- **Nixon–China rapprochement (1969–72).** The US relaxed its trade embargo; three days later China released detained US citizens, then reciprocated further, culminating in Nixon's 1972 visit. → *Illustrates: reciprocity eliciting cooperation between rivals with no world government to enforce it.*
- **Israel–Palestinian tit-for-tat.** Reciprocity works both ways — sustained mutual punishment instead of cooperation. → *Illustrates: reciprocity's runaway-hostility danger (cooperation ≠ automatic).*
- **The European Union.** Shared interests + incentives to defect → an institutional solution (forums, rules, monitoring, courts, issue linkage, repeated interaction). → *Illustrates: liberal institutionalism at full strength — a stable peace built from institutions.*
- **Gulf War (1990–91).** Iraq's blatant annexation of Kuwait united all the great powers behind a UN-authorized response. → *Illustrates: collective security working — clear aggression + willingness to bear costs.*
- **Iraq War (2003).** The Security Council split (France's veto threat); the US/UK acted without UN authorisation. → *Illustrates: collective security's limits when the great powers disagree.*
- **R2P: Libya (2011) vs Syria (2011–).** A UN-authorized NATO campaign protected Libyan civilians; Syria's civilians got no such protection (Russian vetoes). → *Illustrates: the **norm shift** toward protecting civilians — and how **sovereignty + the veto** still block it.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Cooperation puzzle	Why do states cooperate under anarchy? (liberalism's central question)
Liberal institutionalism	Institutions make cooperation easier (Keohane & Nye; international level)
Liberal internationalism	Domestic politics shape state preferences (Kant; domestic level)
Neoliberalism	Concedes realist assumptions (unitary/rational/anarchy) but shows cooperation pays
Reciprocity / shadow of the future	Repeated interaction makes cheating costly → cooperation rational (tit-for-tat)
International regime	Rules/norms/procedures where actor expectations converge (Krasner)
Complex interdependence	Multiple cross-border channels; disruption costly for both (sensitivity vs vulnerability)
Kantian triangle	Democracy + economic interdependence + international organizations → peace
Democratic peace	Democracies almost never fight <i>each other</i>
Collective security	Broad alliance opposing aggression by any actor (League → UN)
UN Security Council / veto	5 permanent members can each block any resolution
International law (sources)	Treaties · custom · general principles · scholarship (enforced by reciprocity)
Just war	<i>jus ad bellum</i> (when war is legal — response to aggression) vs <i>jus in bello</i> (how fought)
R2P	Responsibility to protect civilians from genocide/crimes against humanity (2005)

Exam pointers

- State **liberalism's puzzle** and its answer: keep the **realist assumptions** (rational self-interested states under anarchy) but show **cooperation is often rational** — and that liberalism is **not** "being nice/naïve."
- Distinguish the **two branches** (institutionalism = international/institutions; internationalism = domestic/preferences) and name their theorists (Keohane & Nye; Kant).
- Explain the **four institutionalist mechanisms** (shadow of the future, information/monitoring, reciprocity/enforcement, interdependence) — and define an **international regime** (Krasner) with the institution ≠ IO distinction.
- Draw the **Kantian triangle** and explain the **democratic peace** precisely (democracies rarely fight *each other*; the mechanisms; the caveats).
- Use **ch.7 institutions** as evidence: the **UN/Security Council + veto**, **collective security** (Gulf War vs Iraq 2003), **international law** (4 sources, reciprocity enforcement), **just war**, **human rights/R2P**.

- **Contrast with realism:** same actors, opposite conclusion — see the table below.

★ Realism vs Liberalism — the payoff

	Realism (IR I)	Liberalism (IR II)
Core principle	Dominance (power)	Reciprocity (+ identity)
View of anarchy	Forces self-help & competition	Doesn't make conflict inevitable
Human nature / progress	Pessimistic, timeless	More optimistic; rules evolve toward peace
Key actors & level	Unitary states; systemic level	States + domestic actors; institutions
Cooperation	Hard; fear of relative gains & cheating	Achievable via institutions & absolute gains
Central concepts	Power, security dilemma, balance of power, polarity	Institutions, regimes, interdependence, <u>democratic peace</u>
Both agree on	States are rational actors pursuing self-interest under anarchy	

The one-line contrast: realism asks "who has the power?"; liberalism asks "under what conditions is cooperation in states' own interest?"

★ Fun facts & memorable details (IR II: Liberalism)

Sticky bits from Liberalism.

- **Liberalism ≠ nice.** It keeps realism's rational, self-interested states — it just asks "**when does cooperation pay?**" The optimism is about **incentives**, not about human goodness.
- **We live in one of the least warlike periods ever** — the last **great-power war ended 60+ years ago**, and battle-deaths have fallen from *tens of millions* to *hundreds of thousands* since WWII (the "waning of war").
- **Tit-for-tat** — cooperate first, then simply mirror the other side — is enough to sustain cooperation in a **repeated** Prisoner's Dilemma. No world government required.
- **Kant distrusted democracy** (he feared "mob rule" after watching the French Revolution) — yet his *republics* argument became the democratic peace, liberalism's favourite finding.
- **Democracies fight plenty of wars** — just not against *each other*. The three most war-prone states of the last 200 years were **France, Russia, and Britain**.
- **The UN can't heat its own building:** in the 1990s members owed so much in back dues that the UN couldn't afford to heat its NYC headquarters — the campaign slogan became "**Great nations pay their bills.**"
- **UN peacekeeping isn't in the UN Charter** — Dag Hammarskjöld joked the **blue helmets** were authorised under "**Chapter Six and a Half.**"

- **Diplomats' parking tickets:** immunity means NYC is owed ~\$16 million in unpaid diplomatic parking fines — a tiny, vivid example of **sovereignty vs. law**.
 - **Grotius returns:** the "free seas" principle became law when the **Dutch** (then the **British**) dominated trade and benefited from it — international law often codifies the **hegemon's** interest (cf. *Grotius*, *PET Module 2*).
-